

GAMING CONSOLE

PS4 vs Xbox One. FIGHT! Only one can be crowned champion. Which is the best console money can buy?

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Now that the Xbox One is in India, it's time for the mandatory face-off against the PS4. So here's what we're going to do: compare both consoles on several parameters ranging from real-world applications including gaming, to usability and media consumption. We're hoping your choice will practically make itself by the time you're done reading this – metaphorically speaking, of course, and not in a rogue-AI-taking-over-the-world sort of way.

WHERE CAN YOU BUY A PS4 OR AN XBOX ONE?

The PS4 can be bought online as well as at brick-and-mortar stores. The Xbox One, on the other hand, is sold exclusively on Amazon – three bundles are available starting at ₹39,990. 'Imported' Xbox One

bundles for under ₹35,000 were once freely available in the market, but it appears that Microsoft has done something to curb illegal imports, and these are harder to find.

Simply put, the PS4 is more easily acquired. Then again, if Amazon exclusivity and lack of cash-on-delivery aren't a problem for you, the Xbox One bundles do represent good value for money.

CONSOLE HARDWARE, GAMES & PREMIUM SERVICES

The short version is that both consoles have a respectable catalogue of games right now, and you will be able to experience games like Assassin's Creed Unity and FIFA 15 on the PS4 and Xbox One. However, performance tests have indicated that multi-platform games look and play better on the PS4.



Xbox One – Microsoft's latest offering to Gaming



The PlayStation 4 – power in a nutshell

You will need to subscribe to premium services to play online on both devices, and you'll get access to free content and discounts as an added benefit. An Xbox Live Gold subscription will cost you ₹3,400 a year, while a Playstation Plus subscription is ₹450 cheaper.

COMPANION AND CONSOLE APPS

The Xbox One's dedicated Skype and YouTube (only accessible via browser on PS4) apps make using both those services easy to use. In addition to the apps, Internet Explorer offers a far superior browsing experience compared to the PS4's default browser.

In terms of companion apps, the Xbox SmartGlass and the Playstation mobile app save us the bother of typing and performing mundane

tasks on a controller. SmartGlass is clearly the superior app. It's more polished, feature-rich and is supported on Windows 8 in addition to mobile devices. The Playstation app is a mobile site masquerading as a full-feature mobile application.

HOME MEDIA STREAMING

Video playback from any Windows Media Center 7 or Windows 8.1 PC is supported natively on Xbox One allowing you to play videos directly from a source device. The PS4 doesn't natively support DLNA, and as a result, pulling content from a media server isn't something it can do directly. However, a work around exists. Plex is a media server accessible via the PS4's browser to play back content.

We'd say Microsoft wins this round for native streaming support, Windows integration and easier setup.

THE VERDICT

The Xbox One wins the smaller battles. The more polished user experience can be attributed to companion apps, Windows integration, and media streaming out of the box. Nifty features like HDMI passthrough and native Skype and YouTube apps are a plus. But barely makes up for the fact that multi-platform games on the Xbox One are likely to be inferior to PS4 versions.

If you're the kind of gamer who wants a dedicated gaming console with processing power, visual fidelity and performance, the PS4 fits the bill perfectly. It's a no-nonsense machine that does a good, if not spectacular job as a media consumption device. The PS4 comes out on top where it counts, and because of this, it is our winner in this face-off. **D**